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1. Study Courses

The following types of study or training courses allow non-EU students to apply for a study visa (Type D4 for long-term or Type E6 for short-term) in Portugal:

- Higher education programs including Bachelor's, Master's, and Doctorate (PhD) degrees.
- Research activities or doctoral programs.
- Student exchange programs for secondary education.
- Professional training/vocational courses.
- Unpaid internships.
- Volunteer work programs.
- Language courses (usually as part of a broader study plan or for programs exceeding 90 days).

2. Embassy Appointment

Booking an appointment at a Portuguese embassy or consulate generally follows these methods:

- Online Visa Portal: Most applications begin on the Portuguese Ministry of Foreign Affairs (MNE) E-visa portal.
- VFS Global: In many countries, the Portuguese government outsources the collection of visa applications to VFS Global. Applicants must register on the VFS website specific to their country to book a slot.
- Direct Email/Phone: In jurisdictions where VFS is not available, students must contact the consular section of the Portuguese Embassy directly via their official email or telephone.

3. Applying for a Study Visa

The application process for a Portuguese study visa involves several stages:

How to Apply

- Register and fill out the online application form on the E-visa portal.
- Gather all required physical documents.
- Schedule and attend an interview at the consulate or VFS center to submit documents and provide biometric data (fingerprints).
- Pay the visa processing fee.

How Long it Usually Takes

- The legal deadline for a decision on a residence visa (Type D) is 60 days.
- The legal deadline for a temporary stay visa is 30 days.
- Processing times can vary significantly depending on the volume of applications and the specific consulate, often taking between 2 to 4 months.

4. Documents Needed

Before applying, students must prepare the following:

- National visa application form, filled and signed.
- Passport valid for at least three months beyond the intended stay.
- Two recent passport-sized color photographs.
- Proof of regular status if applying from a country other than the country of origin.
- Criminal record certificate from the country of origin or residence (must be apostilled or legalized).
- Permission for AIMA (Agency for Integration, Migration, and Asylum) to check Portuguese criminal records.
- Valid travel medical insurance (minimum coverage of €30,000, including repatriation).
- Proof of accommodation (lease agreement, university residence letter, or "term of responsibility" from a host).
- Letter of Acceptance/Enrollment from a Portuguese educational institution.
- Proof of financial means (bank statements, scholarship grant, or term of responsibility).

5. Money Requirements

Students must prove they have sufficient funds to cover their stay:

- The calculation is based on the Portuguese Minimum Wage (Salário Mínimo Nacional). As of 2024, the minimum wage is €820 per month.
- Students generally need to prove they have 100% of the minimum wage for the first month, and 50% for the subsequent months of the first year, or a full 100% for every month depending on the specific consulate's interpretation.
- For a 12-month stay, a student should aim to show a minimum of approximately €9,840 available in a bank account.
- If the student has a scholarship or a "term of responsibility" signed by a Portuguese citizen/resident, the financial requirement may be waived or reduced.

6. Residence Permit

The study visa (Type D) allows two entries and is valid for 120 days. During this period, the student must apply for a residence permit:

- Upon arrival, the student must check if their visa includes a pre-scheduled appointment date and time with AIMA (listed on the visa sticker or an accompanying document).
- If no appointment is pre-scheduled, the student must call the AIMA contact center to book an appointment.
- The student must attend the AIMA appointment to submit updated documents (Portuguese bank account, NIF number, and proof of address in Portugal) to receive their Residence Permit card.

7. Working While Studying

Non-EU students in Portugal are permitted to work:

- Students are allowed to work up to 20 hours per week during the academic semester.
- Full-time work is permitted during holidays and academic breaks.
- The student must notify AIMA regarding the commencement of a work activity.
- The work must not interfere with the student's study schedule or academic performance.

8. Renewing the Residence Permit

If the course lasts longer than the validity of the residence permit (usually 1 or 2 years):

- The student must request a renewal 30 to 90 days before the current permit expires.
- Renewal is often processed through the AIMA online portal (Automatic Renewal) for certain categories.
- The student must provide proof of enrollment for the new academic year and proof of successful completion of the previous year's subjects (academic transcript).
- Updated proof of financial means and accommodation is required.

9. Changing to a Work Permit

After graduating, students can transition to a work permit:

- Graduates may apply for a residence permit for the purpose of searching for work (valid for one year) or for a permit to work as an employee or independent professional.

- The student must have a valid job contract or a job offer.
- The process involves applying for a change of status (Artigo 90 for highly qualified activity or Artigo 88/89 for general work) through AIMA.
- Evidence of the academic degree obtained in Portugal must be provided.

10. Official Information

Official government information can be found at:

- Portal de Vistos (Ministry of Foreign Affairs): <https://vistos.mne.gov.pt>
- AIMA (Agency for Integration, Migration and Asylum): <https://aima.gov.pt>
- Study in Portugal (Official Higher Education Portal): <https://www.studyinportugal.edu.pt>

11. Application Forms

Forms can be downloaded from:

- Ministry of Foreign Affairs Forms Page: <https://vistos.mne.gov.pt/en/visa-models>
- VFS Global Portugal website: (Specific to the applicant's country).

12. Tips for Students

- Apostille Documents: Ensure your criminal record and academic certificates are apostilled (Hague Convention) or legalized by the Portuguese consulate in your home country before leaving.
- NIF and Bank Account: Apply for a Portuguese Tax Number (NIF) and open a Portuguese bank account as soon as possible, as these are often required for the residence permit.
- Health Insurance: Ensure your insurance is valid for the entire duration of the visa (120 days) and covers the whole Schengen area.
- Timing: Start the application at least 3-4 months before the course start date, as consulate slots fill up quickly.
- Direct Communication: Check the specific requirements of the consulate where you are applying, as small variations in document requirements (like "term of responsibility" formats) can occur between different regions.

1. Study Courses That Qualify

A non-EU/EEA student needs a long-stay national visa (Type D / D4) for any study activity in Portugal lasting more than 90 days, including:

- Higher education programs (bachelor's, master's, PhD) at a recognized Portuguese institution
- Secondary education and vocational/professional training courses (levels 4–5 of the National Qualifications Framework)
- Research projects and academic exchange programs
- Unpaid internships and traineeships linked to a recognized program
- Volunteer programs

For courses of 90 days or less, a short-stay Schengen visa (Type C) may be sufficient, depending on nationality.

Official source: vistos.mne.gov.pt – Ministry of Foreign Affairs Visa Portal

2. Booking an Embassy/Consulate Appointment

- Appointments are made at the Portuguese embassy or consulate covering the student's country of residence
- Many countries use the e-Visa online platform or VFS Global visa application centers (Portugal's outsourced partner in several countries) for scheduling
- Students should only book an appointment after gathering the complete document set, since an incomplete file or incorrect documentation can lead to a rejection notice, which extends the processing time
- Some posts only accept scheduling requests by email with specific details (full name, date of birth, passport number, institution, phone number) before confirming a date

Official source: vistos.mne.gov.pt and the relevant Portuguese embassy/consulate website for the student's country

3. Steps to Apply for a Study Visa in Portugal

Documents needed: see Section 4 below.

How to apply:

- Secure admission/acceptance from a Portuguese educational institution
- Book a visa appointment at the Portuguese embassy/consulate in the home country (or VFS center where applicable)
- Submit the application in person with all original documents plus copies

- Pay the visa processing fee
- Attend an interview if requested by the consular post

How long it takes:

- The decision deadline for a residence visa application is, except for legal exceptions, 60 days
- Some consulates note actual processing can run longer in practice, so applying well in advance is recommended

Official source: vistos.mne.gov.pt

4. Documents Needed

General requirements for a D4 (residence) visa typically include:

- Valid passport with at least two blank pages
- Recent passport-style photographs
- Proof of acceptance/admission from a recognized Portuguese institution
- Proof of accommodation in Portugal
- Proof of means of subsistence (see Section 5)
- Health/travel insurance valid for the trip (residence visa insurance must cover at least one year)
- Criminal record certificate from the home country (or country of residence for over a year)
- Completed and signed national visa application form
- Visa fee payment receipt

Some categories (e.g., scholarship holders) are exempt from certain proofs, such as the means-of-subsistence document.

Official source: vistos.mne.gov.pt – Documentação instrutória / Residência

5. Money Requirements

- The reference amount is tied to Portugal's national minimum wage
- The minimum wage reference for means of subsistence in 2026 is 920 euros, set by Decreto-Lei n.º 139/2025
- This is calculated per person in the household:
 - First adult: 100% of the reference value
 - Second or additional adults: 50%
 - Children under 18 or dependent children: 30%
- For a full year of study, this generally works out to roughly 920 euros x 12 months for the main applicant, though consulates may request bank statements, scholarship letters, a sponsorship declaration ("termo de responsabilidade"), or a combination of these as proof

Official source: vistos.mne.gov.pt – Meios de subsistência

6. Applying for a Residence Permit After Arrival

- The residence visa itself is valid for two entries and a limited window (commonly cited as around 4 months) during which the holder must request a residence permit
- The request is made with AIMA (Agência para a Integração, Migrações e Asilo), the agency that replaced SEF
- Students typically need an appointment at a "Loja AIMA" or through the relevant online channel, and must bring:
 - Passport and the residence visa
 - Proof of enrollment/matriculation
 - Proof of accommodation
 - Proof of means of subsistence
 - Health insurance or proof of coverage by the National Health Service (SNS)
- Once approved, the residence permit (autorização de residência) for higher education students is valid for one year and renewable

Official source: aima.gov.pt – Estudar / Autorização de Residência para Estudantes (Art. 91º/92º)

7. Working While Studying

- Students enrolled in **higher education** (bachelor's, master's, PhD) may carry out a professional activity, subordinate or self-employed, as an activity **complementary** to their studies
- This requires notifying AIMA and providing an employment contract or activity declaration plus Social Security registration proof, under Article 97 of the Foreign Nationals Law (REPSAE)
- **Secondary school students** are generally not authorized to work, even if they hold a residence permit
- Note: Portugal's current legal text does not set a specific maximum number of weekly hours for higher-education students in the official AIMA pages reviewed; some non-official guides mention an informal limit around 20 hours/week during term time, but students should confirm any hour limits directly with AIMA or their university, since the legal requirement is "complementary to studies," not a fixed numeric cap

Official source: aima.gov.pt – Estudar (Art. 91º/97º REPSAE)

8. Renewing the Residence Permit

- If the course lasts longer than one year, the residence permit must be renewed before it expires
- Renewals are generally processed through AIMA's official renewal channels (e.g., the Portal das Renovações), which validate fiscal and Social Security status automatically
- Required documents commonly include: current residence permit (even if recently expired), valid passport, proof of address, proof of continued enrollment, and updated proof of means of subsistence
- Renewal periods generally match the original permit's logic (one-year periods for standard student permits)

Official source: aima.gov.pt

9. Changing to a Work Permit After Studies

Yes, this is possible, but the process depends on the situation:

- **Job-seeking period:** Higher education graduates (or those who completed a research project) may request to benefit from up to one year to search for work or start a business compatible with their qualifications, under Article 122(1)(p) of REPSAE
- **Switching to employment:** Students who find a job or become self-employed must request a change in the type of residence permit (not a simple renewal), since the legal basis for residing in Portugal changes from "study" to "work"
- This request is made through AIMA's dedicated contact form (not the standard renewal portal), and requires:
 - Copy of passport and current residence permit
 - Proof of completed studies (or research project)
 - Employment contract, service agreement, or proof of registering as self-employed with the Tax Authority
 - Proof of Social Security registration (NISS)

Official source: aima.gov.pt – Trábalhar (Art. 122º REPSAE)

10. Official Information Sources

- **Ministry of Foreign Affairs – Visa Portal:** vistos.mne.gov.pt (visa types, fees, processing times, required documentation, legislation)
- **AIMA (Agency for Integration, Migration and Asylum):** aima.gov.pt (residence permits, renewals, work authorization, legal texts)
- **European Commission – EU Immigration Portal, Portugal section:** home-affairs.ec.europa.eu (EU-level overview, conditions to study in Portugal as a non-EU citizen)

- **Portuguese embassy/consulate website** for the student's specific country, which lists local procedures, appointment systems, and any country-specific requirements

11. Where to Download Official Application Forms

- National visa application forms (Schengen and national/residence types, including the D4 study visa) are published on vistos.mne.gov.pt and mirrored on individual embassy/consulate websites
- AIMA publishes its own forms (e.g., the "termo de responsabilidade," contact forms for residence permit changes) on aima.gov.pt
- Some embassies host a direct downloadable list of all visa types (D1–D9 etc.) on their consular section page

12. Common Mistakes Students Make

- Submitting an incomplete or incorrectly filled document set, which can result in a rejection notice and a longer overall procedure
- Applying too close to the intended travel or course start date, given the official decision period (up to 60 days) plus appointment wait times
- Underestimating the proof of means of subsistence, or submitting bank statements that don't clearly show the required reference amount per month
- Not booking the AIMA residence permit appointment soon enough after arrival, since the residence visa's entry window is limited
- Starting paid work without first notifying AIMA, which can create irregularities affecting future renewals
- Not checking whether their specific nationality or course type qualifies for fee exemptions or simplified procedures (e.g., government scholarship holders, CPLP nationals)

A few notes on accuracy: visa fees, the minimum wage reference figure, and processing rules are reviewed periodically by the Portuguese government, so it's worth checking vistos.mne.gov.pt and aima.gov.pt directly (or the relevant embassy) shortly before applying, since these figures and procedures (especially around AIMA's renewal portal and work-permit transition process) have changed multiple times recently.